

UNCOVERING THE INTELLECTUAL DIVERSITY OF COMMON LINES OF ARGUMENT IN MODERN POLICY DEBATE: DISCOVERING AN ANSWER TO THE MEDIA'S CALL FOR RENEWED DISCUSSION IN POST-SECONDARY EDUCATION

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In an age of fierce controversy over globalization, terrorism, immigration, and education, colleges are being called upon to serve as incubators of discussion and debate. The media have posited colleges as sites ripe with potential for citizenship training (Bacow, 2005; Ehrlich, 2003; Vinovskis, 2005); yet often highlight existing impediments such as a lack of senior faculty presence in classrooms and climates that are hostile to diverse opinions. Critics charge that the best professors rarely teach, and that even when they do they eschew controversial topics such as religion because they are ill-equipped to lead discussions on those issues (Vinovskis, 2005).

Professors and college administrators have been caught in the crossfire of quarrels that unnecessarily pit free expression against tolerance (Annab, 2004; Brown, 2006; Ensslin, 2005; Fischer, 2006; Gravios, 2006; Leo, 2004; Rojstaczer, 2004; Waldron, 2006). Noted scholars have lamented that important ideas are being lost because of misguided decisions to abandon controversial texts in favor of less contentious readings (Brier, 2006; Harpham, 2006; Kellman, 2006). Nascent speech codes have been defended as indispensable for minimizing rhetorical violence and participant exclusion despite their frequent employment to

exclude traditionally disenfranchised voices (Gravios, 2006; Fischer, 2006).

Amidst the cacophony of criticisms, colleges are attempting to deliver more civics and debate instruction. For instance, citizenship training is re-emerging from the ashes of its former glory (Colby, et. al., 2003; Sax, 2004) and finding its way into Public Affairs and Political Science courses (Rice, 2004; Ryan, 2006). Pedagogies aimed at immersing students in famous political debates of the past are taking root at colleges across the United States, most notably via the Reacting to the Past curriculum developed at Barnard College and implemented at more than 25 colleges (Carnes, 2004; Carnes, 2005; Hughes, Stevenson, & Gershovich, 2006; Lee, 2005; Light, 2004; Slater, 2005). Meetings of college educators such as the International Society for Exploring Teaching and Learning (ISETL) and the Teaching Professor Conference are featuring workshops designed to assist professors as discussion leaders and debate moderators.¹ Finally, colleges are implementing new debate initiatives such as collegiate Ethics Bowls and NYU's highly celebrated Zuckerman Forum debate scholarship competition. These innovations are drawing upon the power of organized, competitive debate to serve as models for "exchange[s] of diverse viewpoints" ("Most valuable polemics...", 2005, online. See also *Zuckerman Forum*, 2006). Because many of these programs draw upon existing policy debate practices, resources, and personnel, they offer a unique opportunity for debaters, their coaches, and debate administrators to shape discourse about the future of campus debate initiatives. This newfound privilege begs the question: can competitive policy debate stand up to the charges lobbied at modern post-secondary

¹ Recent presentation titles include: "Diversity & civic engagement in learning-centered communities" (ISETL, 2006) and "Managing classroom discussion: Balancing the voices and integrating contributions" (Teaching Professor, 2006). Visit www.isetl.org and http://www.teachingprofessor.com/2006_Conference/workshops_sessions.html. Last accessed September 12, 2006.

institutions and emerge as a site for open discussion about a diverse set of topics and viewpoints?

Almost since the first policy proposition was debated in the 1920s (Bartanen, 2002), scholars have been writing about the aims and practices of competitive debate. The corpus of debate scholarship now numbers roughly 700 articles (Rogers, 2002). Much of that literature has consisted of heated exchanges – often polemical – over the state of argumentation praxis in America (see for example, Shanahan, 2004; Solt, 2004). Though often critical of the evolution of new debate trends, the literature offers strong support for the types of benefits policy debate affords student competitors. At least three such benefits are often discussed: a.) development of intellectual and behavioral skills and abilities; b.) acquaintance with people and places outside one's typical universe; and c.) interaction with a diverse set of ideas and arguments.

That debate encourages the development of intellectual skills such as “critical thinking, research identification, collection, organization and assimilation, evidence evaluation, practical and theoretical argument and counter-argument development, persuasive writing, and intelligent, articulate oral advocacy” (Rogers, 2002, p. 1) seems self-evident to debaters and coaches. Debaters are fond of proclaiming folk wisdom such as “the faster you can talk, the faster you can think!” However, both the average debater and the casual observer “would be surprised at the ferocity of the criticism directed toward participation in debate” in disciplinary journals (Williams, McGee, & Worth, 2001, p. 198). For decades, a vitriolic back-and-forth exchange has consumed hundreds of pages of journal space. Solid empirical evidence, not based upon self-report data or collections of anecdotes, has been in short supply. Additionally, scholars have been sharply divided over whether the existing evidence indicates that debate falls short of the pedagogical value attributed to it (see Burnett, Brand, & Meister, 2001; Greenstreet, 1993; Hill, 1993) or reveals that debate benefits students intellectually and behaviorally (Bellon, 2000; Millsap, 1998; Rogers, 2002; Williams, McGee, & Worth, 2001).

In response to the rift, Jack E. Rogers conducted a complex four-year longitudinal study which utilized survey instruments distilled from a detailed review of the literature and focus groups of debate administrators, program directors, and students. The surveys were initially distributed to 760 incoming first-year students (563 non-debaters and 197 debaters at twenty-eight diverse institutions). Based upon the intake survey, 100 debate and 100 non-debate students were selected for participation in a four-year study. At its conclusion, Rogers discovered that debaters possessed five positive traits:

1. They were more *socially responsible* as indicated by increased voting, volunteering, and participation in activist pursuits;
2. They were more *culturally tolerant* and aware as shown by their likeliness to enroll in “cross-cultural coursework... and exhibit tolerance for and acceptance of the views and contributions of other races, religions, cultures, and issues of sexual preference...” (p. 21);
3. They were more *academically successful* as evidenced by slightly higher GPAs, a significantly greater rate of professional internship experiences, acceptance to graduate school, and jobs in their majors post-graduation;
4. They were more *morally grounded and flexible* as demonstrated by an orientation to the just society tradition and a decreased likelihood to ignore viewpoints and beliefs which contradicted with their own;
5. They were more *psychologically well-adjusted* as denoted by their lower rates of self-reported anxiety and depression and higher self-reported confidence and positive outlooks (Rogers, 2002, pp. 21-22).

Whether the rigor of Rogers’ study will quiet critics of debate remains to be seen. For now, it serves to strengthen the claims made by debaters, coaches, and administrators about both the intellectual, and perhaps even more importantly, behavioral and

social benefits of participation in debate. In light of the current undercurrent of xenophobia in America, it is debaters' increased cultural tolerance and moral flexibility that most directly speaks to the media's calls for colleges to serve as incubators of discussion and debate. It is this acquaintance with people, places, and ideas outside one's typical universe that serves as one of debate's shining contributions to students' lives.

At the 2001 deca-annual Tahoe Conference on Academic Debate, Erwin Chemerinsky, distinguished Professor at the University Southern California School of Law, declared in his keynote address, "Debate was the most important part of my high school and college education" (2001, p. 63). Although Chemerinsky initially joked that one of the enormously valuable skills he garnered from debate was the ability to "fall asleep in any moving vehicle within seconds," he then moved to more serious terrain. Debate had taught him, in a meaningful way, about people and places he had never known or even imagined. It was in this sense that he gained an incredible perspective on diversity:

I grew up in a working class family in Chicago and never had been far from Chicago... until debate. About a decade ago, I was having a conversation with a colleague. He said that he and his family were going to Europe for vacation. I said that sounded great, that I never had been. He was quite surprised when I told him...I never had a passport or had traveled out of the country. He looked shocked and said, "You mean that your parents never took you to Europe?" I said that as a kid the farthest I'd gone from Chicago was to Gary, Indiana... But debate changed all that... After my junior year, I was thinking seriously of not debating my senior year. My coach, David Zarefsky, asked if there were things I hadn't done that I wanted to do. I said that I'd like to see more of the cities we were visiting. And so my senior year, we spent an extra day in places where there were interesting things to see; we didn't spend any extra time at Dartmouth, but the extra time in places like

Houston and San Francisco was wonderful” (2001, p. 65).

Chemerinsky also counted his cadre of friends as among the most valuable benefits of debate participation. Of course, both in Chemerinsky’s debating days as well as today, the reach of one’s debate friendships can extend only so far as the diversity of the debate population will allow. The more diverse the pool of participants, the better for all involved. Unfortunately, the sphere of competitive college policy debate has often fallen short of encompassing meaningful and proportionately representative diversity.

A host of studies have criticized competitive college policy debate for its lack of participant diversity and its privileging of highly competitive argument styles which reinforce Western, patriarchal, heteronormative values and rational frameworks (Allen, et. al., 2004; Bruschke, 2004; Burnett, Brand, & Meister, 2001; McRee & Cote, 2002; Stepp & Gardner, 2001; Warner & Bruschke, 2001; Williams & Hughes, 2003; Zompetti, 2004). The great hope for change has been the national urban debate league (UDL) movement (Warner & Bruschke, 2001), “a group of efforts in cities across America to generate competitive debating opportunities at poorer high schools” (Bruschke, 2004). Ideally, UDLs would recruit students from diverse racial, ethnic, and socio-economic backgrounds. Once graduated from their high school programs, UDL students would join their colleges’ squads, increasing both representational and ideological diversity in college debate. According to Bruschke, this goal has yet to be realized:

Whatever benefits these leagues have offered their participants, they have not managed to change ethnic participation levels in college debate. It kills me to say that, since I’m one of the guys running one of those UDLs... If even a very small percentage of... [the 10,000 high school students that have participated in UDLs] went on to college debate there should be an obvious and profound change in participation by ethnic group, and that has not happened (2004, p. 86).

The answer to college debate's diversity issues is complicated, because the causes underlying the lack of diversity are many-fold. At the core, lack of diversity in any activity can generally be attributed to either failing to extend invitations to "non-traditional" participants or failing to provide a service or activity that those participants deem worthwhile (Walker-Kuhne, 2005). In that sense, debate programs either need to do more inviting or more selling. While this study does not purport to provide instructions for inviting new participants, it does offer fodder for "sales pitches." As Rogers and Chemerinsky demonstrated, one of the biggest appeals of debate is that it affords participants with an unmatched opportunity to interact with a diverse set of ideas and arguments.

Yet, in recent history, there has been no attempt to catalogue that argument diversity. While scholars such as Rogers have compellingly demonstrated the intellectual flexibility engendered by exposure to a wide range of ideas, no studies have investigated how many lines of argument debaters actually employ. Lines of argument, referred to as *topoi* or *loci* (Corbett, 1965; Perelman & Olbrechts-Tyteca; Zompetti, 2000), serve as "storehouses" of information that debaters can employ in individual debate rounds and utilize outside of debate. If we take seriously the contention that debaters become more intellectually and socially aware and flexible, and marry that with Aristotle's conception of *topoi* as places in which arguments reside (Kennedy, 1991), then each distinct line of argumentation represents a mental space created to house related thoughts. With each exposure to a new line of argumentation, debaters necessarily create emergent, epistemic catalogues in their minds and psyches.

Based upon an extensive survey of debate coaches, this study attempts to catalogue the intellectual nooks and crannies fashioned by common lines of argument employed in contemporary competitive college policy debate. From their vantage point as judges, some of whom have decades of perspective, coaches are in a unique position to comment upon the lay of the land for three reasons. First, their tenure is often much longer than individual debaters' debate careers. Second, debate coaches reach numerous debaters through their service as coaches,

judges, summer institute lecturers, etc. Finally, as teachers of debate, debate coaches have a vested interest in developing catalogues of argument to impart to their students. This study taps into those catalogues and affords a snapshot of specific lines of argument, or special topoi, developed around common policy debate issues. This brief roadmap of the places created by debaters and collected by coaches serves as an indication of the intellectual diversity fostered by participation in competitive college policy debate.

Methodology

To cull a catalogue of specific lines of argument in contemporary competitive college policy debate, a survey comprised of a series of open and closed questions was distributed to every debate coach registered at either the 2002 National Debate Tournament (NDT) or Cross Examination Debate Association (CEDA) National Championship. A total of 263 surveys were distributed: 212 surveys were sent electronically via e-mail and an additional 51 surveys were distributed manually at the 2002 NDT, 2002 CEDA National Championship, and two summer debate institutes.² Demographic characteristics surveyed included field of study, debate experience prior to coaching, and formal training in argumentation or logic (i.e. completion of an argumentation class). Of the coaches surveyed, two distinct groups emerged and accounted for the vast majority of the sample. Group 1, “experts,” was characterized by coaches with prior debate experience and academic training in argumentation and logic. Of these twenty-three experts, all had majored in communication in either undergraduate or graduate school. Group 2, comprised of thirteen “non-experts,” had not majored in communication, had little to no prior experience in debate, and had received no formal training in argumentation or logic. The remaining participants had a mix of

² There might have been some overlap in the survey distribution. For example, some coaches might have received surveys both in person and via e-mail. There is no evidence that any of the returned surveys were duplicates.

formal training, debate experience, and familiarity with the communication discipline.

Participants were asked a series of open-ended questions designed to capture lines of argument related to common policy debate issues. Those questions were:

1. What major, substantive, generic lines of argument would you expect to find in almost any debate on an environmental topic?
2. What major, substantive, generic lines of argument would you expect to find in almost any debate on a legal topic?
3. What major, substantive, generic lines of argument would you expect to find in almost any debate on an international topic?

A final question sought to capture more general lines of argument:

4. What major, substantive, generic lines of argument would you expect to find in almost any debate regardless of its topic?

Results of the surveys were analyzed and distinct lines of argument were counted toward the total for each question. Key words and phrases related to specific lines of argument were also included in the results. For example, in response to question 1, "What major, substantive, generic lines of argument would you expect to find in almost any debate on an environmental topic?" respondents indicated economic arguments related to "economic growth, industry flight, and business confidence." The decision to document major lines of argument, while retaining descriptive language, was undertaken so as to avoid the charge that this study "overstates" the diversity of arguments present in contemporary policy debate. This conservative approach serves to provide the most solid ground possible for our contention that there is incredible argument diversity within competitive college policy debate. Because the respondents' language could be grouped in a variety of ways, we have provided it alongside our categories in order to facilitate others' use of the data.

The Results: 114 Different Lines of Argument

In response to the first question, regarding major lines of argument in debates about the environment, respondents indicated twenty-seven major lines of argument.

Table 1. Environment Arguments

Major Argument	Respondents' Language	# of Responses
Economics	Economic growth, industry fight, business confident	38
Politics	Politics, political process, elections, bipartisanship, political capital, focus	24
Climate	Global warming, climate, ice age	23
Species	Species loss, biodiversity	23
Environmental Critiques	Anthropocentrism, Deep ecology, Environmental ethics, Technology K	18
Movements	Social movements, movements	17
Agent Counterplans	Agent CPs, State CPs, Voluntary CP	13
Regulation	Regulation, effectiveness of regulation	12
Modeling	Local vs. international action, global implications, modeling	9
Scientific Critiques	Doomsday critiques, questions of scientific methodology	9
Feminism	Ecological feminism, feminism	8
Pollution	Acid rain, toxic waste, ozone	7
Cost	Cost, spending, budget	6

Morality	Morality, rights, utilitarianism	4
Capitalism	Capitalism, consumerism	4
Federalism	Federalism	4
Population	Overpopulation, Malthus	2
Critical Legal Studies	CLS	2
Colonialism	Cultural imperialism	2
EPA	EPA, EPA Superfund	2
Environmental Racism	Environmental racism	2
Deforestation	Deforestation	1
Justice	Justice	1
Space	Space	1
Property Rights	Property rights	1
Energy	Oil, renewable resources	1
International Relations	International relations	1

In response to the second question, regarding major lines of argument in debates about legal topics, respondents indicated thirty-six major lines of argument.

Table 2: Legal Arguments

Major Argument	Respondents' Language	# of Respondents
Critical Legal Studies	CLS	36
Legal Process	Questions of legal process, court implementation, constitutionality, Congressional implementation, separation of powers, jurisdiction	28
Politics	Politics, political implications	21
Morality	Morality, utilitarianism, deontology, human	17

	rights, individualism, communitarianism	
Agent Counterplans	Agent CP, state CP, court CP	15
Feminism	Feminism, gender, Butler, gender jurisprudence	15
Legitimacy	Court credibility, legitimacy	15
Discrimination	Discrimination, racism, sexism, classism, intersectionality	12
Critical Race Theory	CRT	11
Movements	Movements, social movements	11
Precedent	Precedent, stare decisis, legal definition	11
Hollow hope	Hollow hope	9
Judicial activism	Judicial activism	7
Efficiency	Efficiency, court clog	7
Rule of law	Rule of law, anarchy	7
Normativity	Normativity, Schlag	6
Due process	Due process, informed consent	5
Death penalty	Death penalty	4
Cost	Spending cost, budget	3
Economics	Economy, economic growth, business confidence	3
Democracy	Net widening, democracy, authoritarianism	3
Modeling	Modeling, international modeling	3
Crime	Crime	2
Abortion	Abortion	1

Expertise critique	Critiques of experts	1
Retribution	Retribution	1
Deterrence	Deterrence	1
Foucault	Foucault	1
Marxism	Marxism	1
Corruption	Corruption	1
Statism	Statism	1
Justice	Rawls	1
Colonialism	Colonialism	1
Realism	Realism	1
Sensationalism	Media sensationalism	1

In response to the third question, regarding major lines of argument in debates about foreign policy topics, respondents indicated twenty-nine major lines of argument.

Table 3: Foreign Policy Arguments

Major Arguments	Respondents' Language	# of Respondents
US Hegemony	US leadership, hegemony, isolationism, effect plan has on US power	28
Relations	International relations, relations, effect of foreign policy on other countries	27
Politics	Politics, political process, domestic politics	24
International CPs	International CP, country CP, regional alternatives, international organization alternatives, consultation CPs	20
Economics	Trade, economic growth, globalization	14

Feminism	Feminism, feminism IR	14
Unilateralism	Multilateralism, unilateralism, bilateralism, questions of framework	13
Sovereignty	Sovereignty, territory disputes, areas of dispute	11
International law	International law, treaties, soft power	10
World government	World government, WOMP, creating a global government	8
Military readiness	Military readiness, civil military relations, overstretch	7
Domestic backlash	Domestic backlash	7
Statism	Statism	7
Cost	Cost, spending, budget	6
Threat construction	Threat construction, Lipschultz	5
Colonialism	Colonialism, imperialism, neocolonialism	5
Realism	Realism	4
Movements	Movements, social movements	4
Democracy promotion	Democracy promotion	4
Human rights credibility	Soft power, human rights credibility	4
Proliferation	Proliferation, nuclear proliferation	3
Spanos	Spanos	2
Whiteness	Whiteness	1
Presidential credibility	Presidential credibility	1
Nuclearism	Nuclearism	1
Foreign aid	Foreign aid	1

Diversion	Diversion	1
Holocaust trivialization	Numbing	1
Speaking for others	Speaking for others	1

Finally, respondents indicated twenty-two general lines of argument.

Table 4: General Arguments

Major Argument	Respondents' Language	# of Responses
Politics	Political implications, political process, politics	35
Alternatives	Agent CPs, CPs, actor issues	24
Economics	Economic arguments, trade protectionism, inflation, interest rates, business confidence	14
Solvency	Solvency, enforcement, implementation	13
Critiques	Critical arguments, critiques	13
Cost	Cost implications, spending, budget tradeoff	12
Procedurals	Topicality, theory, procedural arguments	11
Feminism	Feminism, gender	7
Discrimination	Racism, sexism, classism	4
International relations	International relations	4
Movements	Social movements	3
Federalism	Federalism	3
Normativity	Normativity	2
Plan Inclusive CPs	PICS	2
Statism	Statism	2
Morality	Moral issues, values	2
Foucault	Foucault	1

Spanos	Spanos	1
US leadership	US leadership	1
Delay CPs	Delay CPs	1
Modeling	International modeling	1
Public backlash	Public backlash	1

A final result worth noting is that there were almost no meaningful differences in the lines of argument listed by experts and non-experts. For example, in response to the first question regarding environmental debates, the top five arguments listed by experts were economics, climate, politics, environmental critiques, and species arguments. The top five arguments listed by non-experts were economics, politics, regulatory effectiveness, species, and international modeling. Noting few substantive variations, we chose not to list the results by coach status category. Additionally, we witnessed that common lines of argument seem to spread throughout the competitive policy debate community and get picked up by coaches with vastly different intellectual heritages. This cross-fertilization of major lines of argument suggests that both participants and coaches are being exposed to a wide range of ideas regardless of the disciplinary paradigms or prior training they bring with them to competitive debate.

Discussion: Does Debate Promote Intellectual Diversity?

The 114 major lines of argument and hundreds of potential smaller arguments gleaned by this survey clearly demonstrate that competitive college policy debate can stand up to the charges lobbied at modern post-secondary institutions and emerge as a site for open discussion about a diverse set of topics and viewpoints. Akin to Rogers' earlier discovery of the argument flexibility engendered by contemporary college policy debate, the lines of argument listed by the respondents suggest that a wide variety of discussions regarding diverse and often highly-contentious arguments are common at modern debate tournaments. It is doubtful that a survey distributed to typical faculty or non-debating college students would yield the breadth of results indicated above. The quantity of arguments is only the first

indicator of argument diversity in contemporary competitive college policy debate, however. Far more important than the number of topics being debated are the types of arguments that consistently make the cut in college policy debate.

The mix of common arguments identified by this study addresses some post CEDA/NDT merger concerns about the nature of argumentation in contemporary policy debate. Since the merger of CEDA and NDT, observers and debate coaches have worried about the loss of arguments endemic to value debate (Bartanen, 2002). According to Bartanen, non-policy resolutions may serve to “free the debater from the supposed constraints of existing policy debate” (2002, p. 76). Additionally, post-merger programs have been criticized for employing “graduate assistants and professional coaches, many without academic backgrounds in argumentation” (Berube, 2002, p. 86), which has arguably led to a marked decrease in “the caliber of coaching” (Berube, 2002, p., 86) and concomitantly the quality of argumentation. While not everyone concurs that the merger or the loss of value topics has impacted competitive college policy debate negatively (Herbeck and Katsulas, 2002), these are nonetheless serious charges with which to contend.

While our study cannot provide empirical pre/post merger data on lines of argumentation or answer all of Berube’s concerns about the present state of academic debate, it nevertheless demonstrates a robust body of arguments currently observed (and arguably taught) by expert and nonexpert CEDA/NDT debate coaches. Additionally, though many arguments could be classified as typical “policy arguments,” many others indicate underlying value orientations. Environmental arguments such as “environmental critiques,” “movements,” “feminism,” “morality,” critical legal studies,” “colonialism,” “environmental racism,” and “justice” suggest that students are grappling with fact and value concerns that are often seen as preceding questions of policy. Additionally, these lines of argument and similar arguments, prevalent across debate topics, demonstrate a resounding concern for issues of representation, equity, social harmony, power imbalances, and the like. That critical legal studies was the most

frequently mentioned major argument utilized in legal debates underscores the power of competitive college policy debate to open students' eyes to questions of institutional inequality. If some college campuses are failing to provide environments in which students debate – even discuss – competing claims about racial prejudice, gender inequality, classism, ableism, and homophobia, our study suggests that the debate community is well versed in those areas. As colleges search for meaningful ways to quell their critics, debate administrators, coaches, and participants, should offer to spearhead the effort to increase the diversity of discussion taking place on campuses. While it might be true that the competitive college policy debate community has not learned how to increase the diversity of its participants, the culture of this competitive activity serves as an incubator for the very discussions that could ultimately serve to resolve recruiting and retention issues. Additionally, as the dozens of policy argument lines suggest, this activity still serves as a laboratory for testing out the pros and cons of plans and counterplans, which could ultimately transcend debate rounds and pave the way toward a more equitable society.

Concluding Remarks

This study provides support for the claim that competitive college policy debate is in an excellent position to serve as a model for discussion and debate in higher education. Debaters discuss a wide-range of highly contentious topics in their pursuit to win policy debate rounds. While professors and college administrators might shy away from directly confronting the topic of institutional racism, for example, this topic will likely be debated in some form, under most resolutions, by most active debate participants. A well-seasoned college debater would likely be familiar with acronyms such as “CRT” and “CLS,” and their attendant intellectual and social movements. While this study does not purport to evidence how possession of that knowledge translates outside of debate rounds, it does suggest that important seeds have been planted during those rounds. Based upon Rogers' detailed empirical study of debaters, we firmly believe that those seeds germinate post-

debate. While not all debaters apply their knowledge of deforestation or court clog to the “real world,” we find it highly probable that debaters are motivated to take positive actions to try to better the world based upon the lines of argument that they found most compelling while competing. This is promising, and deserves more attention.

This attention could focus on how debate can serve to equalize the playing field between those who have power and those involved in struggle. James C. Scott’s description of how peasants, citizens, and scholars resist dominant and oppressive forms of state and bureaucratic control through “weapons of the weak” seems especially germane to this discussion (1985, 1998). Scott posited that successful strategies that create intellectual openness and a more pluralistic society often rely on asymmetrical, non-violent forms of interaction such as protests, land-squatting, and verbal debate. Scott saw sustained, critical, and intense dialogue as more than just a rhetorical strategy: it was a veritable “weapon” to be used by those without power to challenge hegemony and effect change. We see the debate community as a repository of Scottsian “weapon of the weak,” or a training ground for social justice activists.

Future studies would be well advised to use the combined results of Scott’s work, Rogers’ study, and this study as a starting place. Specifically, scholars should examine how lines of argument become ways of living after participants graduate from college policy debate. It would be fascinating to learn about the “feminism” debaters that ended up working in domestic violence clinics or the “anarchy” debaters that sought Ph.D.s in philosophy and became exceptional professors. We are aware of both of these examples and so many more. Together they suggest that argumentation serves a greater purpose than winning. Even if debaters do not realize it during their heated quarter-finals rounds, the arguments that they are making may well serve to alter the courses of their futures. This is the sort of research that we hope will supplement the 700 and counting articles about debate. We also hope that despite the dire predictions for the demise of policy debate, it continues to be an extra-curricular opportunity available

at the undergraduate level. There are at least 114 good reasons why it should.

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